John Lennon and Me

By Cherie Bennett

NOTE: This cutting asks one student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Suggested Roles: ***Actress 1:*** *Star*
Actress 2: *Courtney, Dr. Scott, Claudia, The Torturer, Voice over*

STAR: **(Pg 8-9)** *(Courtney hums Imagine by John Lennon* off stage softly throughout Star's opening monologue)* Allow me to introduce myself. Contrary to what it says on my birth certificate, my name is not Stella Grubner. I renamed myself Star – no last name, thank-you-very-much. I mean, Stella?? *(coughs)* Claudia, my mother – you'll meet her later – tells me that when I was born, she was an actress in New York City. When my mom got pregnant with me, she was in rehearsal for this famous play, A Streetcar Named Desire. Because of me, she had to drop out. So she named me Stella, after the character she never got to play. Then Claudia ran out of money, which is how we ended up moving to this little town outside of Nashville. *(coughs) (Courtney enters)*

(Pg 15) [That's] my roommate, Courtney Cambridge. Prettier than me. Taller than me…

COURTNEY: **(Pg 17)** I've never been sick before . . . I just had this bad sore throat. I didn't tell my mom right away because I didn't want to miss the big away game we had. So then it got worse and worse. It turned out to be strep throat, and that turned into rheumatic fever. And now they think it did something to my heart.

STAR: *(to Courtney)* Can't be that bad. Your lips and your nails aren't blue. *(coughs)* If something is mega-wrong with your heart, you turn blue.

COURTNEY: **(Pg 18)** You don't seem very sick, either. Except for your cough.

STAR: No problem**. (Pg 9)** I plan to run away to New York when I'm seventeen, to become a very famous actress. The sooner the better . . . The thing is, I was born with cystic

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

fibrosis. When I was ten I looked it up in a medical dictionary. It said: "the average life expectancy is twenty-five years. This disease is always fatal." Fatal. As in dead. Well, I am not average. I am extraordinary. So I decided I'm not going to die. I'm just not.

INTRODUCTION

*(Actress 1 hums Let it Be by the Beatles** softly while Actress 2 speaks)*

ACTRESS 2: *According to the CF Foundation, more than 30,000 people in the US are living with cystic fibrosis. It is a fatal disease. But the stats for rheumatic heart disease are even higher. Rheumatic fever causes permanent damage to the heart valves. More than 300,000 people die from its debilitating heart complications each year. These illnesses are termed chronic and require continual monitoring and interventions. There are no cures.*

ACTRESS 1: *But as John Lennon once said, "Count your age by friends, not years. Count your life by smiles, not tears.*

TOGETHER: *John Lennon and Me by Cherie Bennett.*

STAR: **(Pg 9)** *(gestures to her surroundings)* This is Heart House – a place for sick kids. I've probably slept more nights here than I've slept in my own bed. The bad news is my health has taken *(melodramatically)* A Turn For the Worse. *(Dr. Scott enters)* **(Pg 12)** *(to Dr. Scott)* Okay, I coughed up some blood last night. Not much, though. *(coughs)*

DR. SCOTT: How many thumps are you doing each day.

STAR: *(trying to catch her breath)* At home Claudia's giving me two, but The Torturer says I have to start doing three a day. *(Torturer's them music --maybe Jaws – As Ina Tortunesky enters)* It's her idea of a good time . . . *(to audience)* **(Pg 13)** That's her, Mrs. Tortunesky – The Torturer. If she was green, she could pass for The Incredible Hulk. She used to be an army nurse. Whenever I'm at Heart House, she wakes me up every morning at 6 am for physical therapy by barking commands in my face.

THE TORTURER: *(barking her commands to the audience while whacking the air with her hand – Star li-synchs the words at the same time)* Lie still! Turn over! Now, cough! Cough!

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

STAR: *(to audience)* It's supposed to keep me from choking to death on – akay, this is disgusting – thick mucus. After that I have to breath this crap called Pulmozyme through an oxygen mask and then she whacks me again. I really hate her.

DR. SCOTT: She's actually not a bad person. She's just kind of . . . serious.

STAR: Serious? She's sadistic! I heard she whacked one CF kid so hard he flew off the bed and landed in the corner like a hockey puck. And then she yelled . . .

THE TORTURER: Score!!!!

COURTNEY: **(Pg 17)** *(looking at a poster on the wall)* I really like your poster.

STAR: He was the most talented person who ever lived. And he died so young.

COURTNEY: *(horrified)* Paul McCartney is dead??

STAR: That's Lennon. John Lennon. *(rolls her eyes – to audience)* She's killing me!

COURTNEY: **(Pg 18)** You know, I was so nervous coming up here. Walking down the hall, I saw some really sick-looking kids. Two of them were bald!

STAR: Chemo.

COURTNEY: That means they have cancer, right? It was so horrible! I just prayed I wouldn't have a really sick roommate. It would be so embarrassing, like when my best friends comes to visit me, you know?

STAR: Oh, sure. My friends come visit me all the time, too. *(To audience)* Like I was really going to tell her that I actually didn't have any friends outside of Heart House. It's hard to make friends when you don't' go to school. So sue me. I lied. **(Pg 22)** Actually I went to regular school for a while, in fourth grade. But I coughed up blood and all the kids ran out of the room screaming. *(The Torturer's theme music plays – she enters)*

THE TORTURER: **(Pg 24)** So, I haven't seen you in three months. We have much work to do.

STAR: **(Pg 25)** Where are your manners? You could at least say hello to Courtney, my new roommate.

THE TORTURER: *(stepping menacingly toward Courtney)* You don't have cystic fibrosis, correct?

COURTNEY: *(staring in horror)* No! No, I swear I don't! *(Star laughs, which cause her to cough)*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

THE TORTURER: Enough levity. We have work to do

STAR: Watch closely. You are about to see a 13-year-old girl whacked to death.

THE TORTURER: Nonsense, all you'll experience is . . . *(She laughs ominously)* SOME DISCOMFORT. *(The Torturer stands over Star and raises her arm for the first blow.)*

STAR: Hold that thought *(The Torturer freezes. Star steps out of the scene – The Torturer whacks viciously at the air as Star watches and narrates the action to the audience in the style of a prize-fight announcer. Into the mike)* **(Pg 26)** And it's THE TORTURER, moving in fast, striking the first blows. A left jab! Another! She hooks to the body! Ouch! Ladies and gentlemen, our champ is taking a tremendous pounding! What grit! What fortitude! What a true champion! *(A boxing ring bell sounds - She steps back into the scene, coughing, exhausted and having difficulty breathing)*

THE TORTURER: You were very congested. We'll have to work harder this evening *(She exits and Star's Mom, Claudia, enters)*

CLAUDIA: **(Pg 27)** Hi, I'm Star's mom. Call me Claudia.

COURTNEY: Claudia. Okay, Claudia. My name is Courtney, Claudia

STAR: *(to audience)* Clearly Courtney wasn't used to calling someone's mother by her first name. But my mother doesn't look like anyone's mother. I like Claudia and Claudia likes me, but she doesn't like my disease. It scares her too much, which scares me too much, so we never talk about it. I act like it's no big thin, and she acts like she believes me.

CLAUDIA: So, what's kickin', chickens?

STAR: The usual. No biggie.

CLAUDIA: You're such a trouper. *(She kisses Star)* **(Pg 28)** Listen, I've got to go down and fill out some of those endless papers. Later! *(she exits)*

COURTNEY: Your mother is unbelievably fabulous! **(Pg 29)** Why couldn't my father have married someone like her? *(thinking a moment)* You know, I though that being here would be the worst thing in the entire world. But . . . it's not so bad. I guess maybe they put us together because we're not as sick as the others. *(shyly)* I'm really glad you're my roommate. *(she exits)*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

STAR: It's gonna be a riot. *(to audience)* And all I had to do was to spend 24 hours a day pretending I wasn't really very sick at all. No problem. *(beat, Star's façade drops)* **(Pg 31)** Here's the thing. When you're sick, I mean really sick, you live in a different world. It's like . . . like walking by a candy store, and you see all these kids inside, laughing, hanging out, having a great time, but no matter what, you can never do more than press your face against the glass.

*****

DR. SCOTT: **(Pg 35)** *(enters)* Hey, Courtney. We're going to start you on some intravenous antibiotics today. Same stuff you've been taking, but this should help you get better faster.

COURTNEY: Wait a second. Are you telling me that you're going to stick on of those things in my arm like Star has? *(grimaces and holds out her arm. mimes having an IV hooked up – She looks at the IV bag and at her arm)* **(Pg 37)** I hate this thing. My hand hurts.

STAR: It's making you kind of pale.

COURTNEY: *(angry)* **(Pg 39)** I'm stuck in this stupid place with this stupid thing in my arm! *(near tears)* It's no use, Star! I can't do this!

STAR: **(Pg 51)** I – I – I – I- **(Pg 52)** *(Coughs, clear her throat, coughs again, longer and deeper)*

COURTNEY: Star, are you okay? *(more coughing, gagging)* Star? Star?

STAR: **(Pg 53)** Courtney, I think I'm going to – *(She wretches deeply, she can't stop coughing, gasping for air, she holds out her hands, covered in blood)*

COURTNEY: *(horrified)* Oh, my God! *(Screaming and crying hysterically)* Help! Somebody come help! Please! Somebody!

***** **DAYS LATER** *****

STAR: **(Pg 54)** *(To audience)* So, here we are . . . When last we saw The Champ – meaning me – things were not looking too good. We pick up the story the next morning, which is good news, since it means I didn't croak. I could hear Claudia talking, but I was so out of it, it was like listening to them on the radio.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

CLAUDIA: **(Pg 55)** I know all about the lung infection eroding a major artery. But why did she bleed so much more this time? She's been fine. She's a fighter.

DR. SCOTT: Come on, Claudia. You know it's getting worse. Star knows it too. *(a beat)* **(Pg 56)** Call me if she wakes up. *(he exits)*

STAR: *(to audience)* I did wake up, but I couldn't really talk for days and days. Imagine me, not talking! It was a fate ***worse*** than death! *(re-enters scene and awakens from the sedatives)* Where's Courtney?

CLAUDIA: You're awake! Do you remember what happened?

STAR: *(it comes flooding back to her, speaking with difficulty)* Oh, God. I can't believe that happened in front of Courtney. She's going to hate me.

DR. SCOTT: *(enters)* **I heard you talking. How do you feel?**

STAR: **(Pg 57)** I'm fine.

DR. SCOTT: It must have been scary, though. It's okay to say so.

STAR: I was so scared I was going to d . . .

CLAUDIA: *(cutting her off – angrily to Dr. Scott)* Don't tell her to be scared if she's not, for Crissake!

DR. SCOTT: *(also angry)* Star, your mom and I are going down the hall for a little chat, then we'll be back, okay? *(they exit and Courtney enters)*

COURTNEY: **(Pg 58)** How are you feeling?

STAR: I'm fine. What did I miss while the lights were out?

COURTNEY: Why are you making jokes?

STAR: Why not? You needed a little excitement in your life. You must be better, they took your IV out.

COURTNEY: Stop it! I have to talk to you . . . *(Star puts her hands over her ears and sings something like the opening lines of She Loves You by the Beatles*** to down out Courtney)* **(Pg 59)** It was so awful! I thought you were going to die! The blood was everywhere! All that blood . . . Why didn't you tell me?

STAR: *(uncovering her ears)* Tell you what?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

COURTNEY: How sick you are! Your cystic fibrosis – You've lived practically all your life in Heart House.

STAR: I'm not that sick! All it means is that I cough sometimes.

COURTNEY: *(angrily grabs a folded piece of paper from her pocket. She unfolds it and reads it out loud)* Cystic Fibrosis **(Pg 60)** is fatal. The cause of death is chronic respiratory failure. In some patients bleeding from the lungs may result in death due to choking and shock.

STAR: I underestimated you. You are bright enough to use a dictionary.

COURTNEY: Why didn't you just ell me the truth?

STAR: You hate sick kids!

COURTNEY: I never said that!

STAR: You did too! You said you were so glad your roommate wasn't really sick. You said the kids who had cancer were so gross because they lost their hair. What was I supposed to say? "Guess what, Courtney . . . I'm one of ***them***!"

COURTNEY: I didn't understand . . .

STAR: Well, most people don't. Which is exactly why I don't tell anyone.

COURTNEY: So . . . I guess you don't want to be friends with me after all, then.

STAR: *(to audience)* So, go figure. Courtney knew the truth, and she wanted to be my friend anyway. *(Courtney exits; long beat)* **(Pg 77)** So, anyway . . . . Courtney's funeral was two weeks ago . . .

VOICE OVER: *(off stage)* **(Pg 74)** Code blue. Code Blue. Dr. Rhodes, second floor stat *(repeat through Star's next lines)*

STAR: **(Pg 77)** There were a lot of great things about Courtney, but the greatest of all was that she accepted me completely, just as I am. And something about her accepting me made me start to accept me too. It's just about the greatest gift anyone ever gave me.

VOICE OVER: **(Pg 75)** Blood pressure zero. Pulse zero *(a high-pitched buzzer goes off)*

DR. SCOTT: *(off stage)* Courtney's heart was damaged and it ruptured. There was nothing we could have done.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

STAR: **(Pg 76)** *(crying)* I'm so afraid I'll die. I don't want to die! I don't want them to cover my face with a sheet like they did to Courtney. *(composes herself) (Courtney hums Let it Be by the Beatles** softly off stage)* **(Pg 77)** And she's smiling down on me right now, telling me that just like John Lennon, I should enjoy every moment of my time on this planet, however long it is.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Cherie Bennett
ISBN: 978-0871297020
Publisher: Dramatic Publishing
Date (Month/Year): July 1996

AWARD HISTORY

2006 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier – MS
CO State Qualifier
NJ State Qualifier
UT State Qualifier

***Music and Lyrics of Imagine by John Lennon can be found here**
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=EJ72bYyEtBg

****Music and Lyrics of Let it Be by The Beatles can be found here**
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QDYfEBY9NM4

***** Music and Lyrics of She Love You by the Beatles can be found here**
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nGbWU8S3vzs

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY